

POLICY BRIEF

Publication PDF

“REFORMING INDUSTRIAL ATTACHMENT AND INTERNSHIP PROGRAMMES FOR UNIVERSITY STUDENTS”.

Short • Analytical • Evidence-Based • Quantitative • Action-Oriented

College of Human Resource Development Sierra Leone – COHReD University College

Directorate of Research and Innovations

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Policy Area: Higher Education, Employability and Work-Based Learning

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1. Executive Summary

Industrial attachment and internship programmes are intended to bridge the gap between academic knowledge and workplace competence. Yet, where placements are poorly matched, weakly supervised or assessed primarily through attendance and reports, students may complete their attachment without acquiring measurable professional competencies.

The problem is particularly important in Sierra Leone. The International Labor Organization (ILO) Sierra Leone Decent Work Country Programme identifies youth unemployment, skills gaps and labour-market mismatch among major employment challenges, reporting that more than 60% of youth were unemployed in the cited national context.

Sierra Leone's Employment Act, 2023 defines internship as work experience intended to help students and graduates acquire relevant skills and experience or satisfy a qualification requirement. Section 97 provides for stipends or allowances and limits normal working time to 8 hours per day and 40 hours per week.

COHReD should therefore transform industrial attachment from a graduation requirement into a measurable Work-Based Learning and Employability System. The model should introduce verified placements, individual learning plans, dual supervision, competency-based assessment, employer feedback, digital monitoring and graduate outcome tracking.

2. The Policy Problem

The central policy problem is not simply whether students are placed in organisations, but whether placements produce meaningful learning and employability outcomes. Five weaknesses require attention: placement mismatch; weak supervision; attendance-based rather than competency-based assessment; limited employer feedback; and weak post-placement outcome tracking.

COHReD should measure the full chain: Placement → Participation → Learning → Competence → Employer Assessment → Graduation → Employment/Entrepreneurship.

3. Background and Context

Sierra Leone's Employment Act, 2023 recognises internship as a mechanism for gaining relevant skills and experience. It also establishes important protections for interns, including an 8-hour daily/40-hour weekly framework and provision for stipends or allowances.

The wider labour-market context reinforces the need for reform. The ILO highlights employability skills, work experience and stronger links between education and the labour market as important components of improving youth employment. COHReD can respond by making attachment a structured learning, quality-assurance and employability intervention.

4. Evidence and Key Findings

Finding 1 — Youth employability challenge: The ILO's Sierra Leone Decent Work Country Programme reports youth unemployment above 60% in the cited context and identifies skills gaps and labour-market mismatch as major concerns.

Finding 2 — Work experience matters: The ILO identifies work experience and on-the-job learning as important sources of employability skills.

Finding 3 — Internship has a statutory learning purpose: Sierra Leone's Employment Act explicitly links internship to relevant skills and experience.

Finding 4 — Student welfare matters: The Employment Act establishes working-time and stipend/allowance provisions for interns.

Finding 5 — integrated interventions are stronger: ILO evidence indicates that youth employment programmes combining skills, soft skills and certification generally perform better than isolated interventions.

5. Why the Issue Matters

At student level, quality attachment can improve technical competence, communication, teamwork, digital literacy, problem-solving, professional ethics, time management and workplace confidence.

At institutional level, a stronger system can improve academic quality, graduate employability, curriculum relevance, employer engagement and evidence for quality assurance.

At national level, better university-to-work transitions can contribute to reducing skills mismatch and strengthening human capital.

6. Policy Options

Option 1 — Maintain existing system: low immediate cost but weak quality control and limited data.

Option 2 — Department-based reform: allows disciplinary flexibility but may produce inconsistent standards.

Option 3 — Central COHReD system: establishes institutional standards, data and accountability while departments retain discipline-specific responsibilities.

Option 4 — University–Industry Partnership Model: builds long-term employer relationships and employment pathways but requires sustained partnership management.

Preferred option: Option 3 combined with elements of Option 4.

7. Recommended Policy Actions

Action 1 — Establish a COHReD Industrial Attachment and Internship Coordination Unit to manage placement, employer relations, monitoring, assessment and data.

Action 2 — Develop a formal COHReD Industrial Attachment and Internship Policy covering eligibility, placement, supervision, assessment, welfare, reporting and completion.

Action 3 — Introduce placement–programme matching so students are placed in organizations relevant to their academic discipline.

Action 4 — Require formal Memoranda of Understanding with major host organizations.

Action 5 — Introduce compulsory pre-placement orientation covering workplace ethics, communication, safety, confidentiality, safeguarding and professional conduct.

Action 6 — Require an Individual Student Learning Plan identifying 5–10 measurable competencies.

Action 7 — Implement dual supervision: one academic supervisor and one workplace supervisor per student.

Action 8 — Introduce competency-based assessment rather than relying primarily on attendance and reports.

Action 9 — Feed employer feedback directly into curriculum review and quality assurance.

Action 10 — establish an internship and employability database and track graduate outcomes at 3, 6 and 12 months.

8. Conclusion

Industrial attachment should not be measured by the number of students who obtain completion letters. It should be measured by what students learned, what competencies they demonstrated, how employers evaluated them and what happened after graduation.

COHReD University College should institutionalize industrial attachment as a formal Work-Based Learning and Graduate Employability Programme supported by a central database, standardized assessment, employer partnerships and annual outcome reporting.

The reform should move COHReD University College from asking ‘Did our students complete their internship?’ to the more important question: ‘What measurable value did the internship add to the student’s human capital and employment prospects?’

9. References

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COHReD University Policy Statement

“COHReD University College shall transform industrial attachment and internship from a graduation requirement into a structured, competency-based and evidence-driven work-based learning system that connects academic knowledge with workplace skills, employer expectations and measurable graduate employment outcomes”.